The Banks by Tier, and What the Seat Actually Pays

Tier lists rank prestige, and prestige is a proxy for exit optionality rather than for cash. Base salary across all five tiers sits inside a $25,000 band — the Street matches, and it matches quickly. What separates an S from a D is the bonus, the class you are ranked inside, and which headhunters answer your email. Read the pay column as the smaller variable; read the hours column as the price.

> **THE SPREAD, IN ONE PARAGRAPH**
>
> First-year base is roughly $110,000–$120,000 at nearly every firm here. All-in comp runs from about $140,000 at the bottom of D to $250,000-plus at the top of S — a 1.7x spread produced almost entirely by bonus, which is bucketed against your own class. A top-bucket analyst in a twelve-person boutique class and a mid-bucket analyst in a bulge-bracket class of four hundred can sit $80,000 apart doing the same work. The tier buys the bonus pool, the deal exposure and the headhunter list — not the base.

The Five Tiers

Tier	Firms	Base, Year 1	All-In, Year 1	Typical Week
S	Lazard · Evercore · Centerview Partners · Moelis & Company · Goldman Sachs	$110k – $125k	$190k – $250k+ Top bucket at the top boutiques clears $250k	80 – 100 hrs 100–110 on live deals; weekends assumed
A	PJT Partners · Perella Weinberg · Houlihan Lokey · Jefferies · Credit Suisse† · Morgan Stanley · JPMorgan · Bank of America	$110k – $120k	$175k – $230k Boutiques at the top, big banks at the middle	75 – 95 hrs Restructuring runs at S-tier intensity
B	Citi · Barclays · UBS · Wells Fargo · RBC · TD · BNP Paribas · Deutsche Bank · Mizuho	$110k – $120k	$165k – $200k Base is street; the bonus is where the gap opens	70 – 90 hrs Wide group-to-group variance inside one bank
C	HSBC · Nomura · SMBC · Rothschild & Co · Natixis · Crédit Agricole	$100k – $115k	$150k – $190k US platforms smaller than the global brand suggests	65 – 85 hrs Best hours-per-dollar on the page
D	Raymond James · Stifel · William Blair · Haitong · BMO · Canaccord Genuity · SEB · Oppenheimer	$95k – $115k	$140k – $180k Regional offices pay 10–20% below New York	60 – 85 hrs Real weekends exist here more often

What the Ranges Do Not Say

The number you saw…	…and what sits underneath it
Base salary	A fixed cost of hiring. It moves when Goldman moves it and the Street follows within a quarter. Do not choose a seat on it.
Bonus	Bucketed. Top bucket is roughly the top 10–20% of a class, and the bucket — not the bank — is the biggest single driver of the number.
Hours	A group-level fact wearing a bank-level label. Sponsors at a B-tier bank out-hour coverage at an S-tier one. Ask about the desk, not the logo.
The tier itself	A proxy for buy-side screening, not for pay. The value of an S seat shows up two years later in on-cycle, not on the Year 1 W-2.

† Credit Suisse was acquired by UBS in 2023 and no longer recruits as a standalone platform; it is retained here as it appears on the source tier list. Tiering is a community convention, not an objective ranking, and reasonable people place many of these firms one tier in either direction. Educational only; not affiliated with or endorsed by any firm named.

Reading the Tiers: What You Are Buying With the Hours

S · The Advisory Peak

$190K – $250K+ · 80–100 HRS · LAZARD, EVERCORE, CENTERVIEW, MOELIS, GOLDMAN SACHS

- **The pay premium is structural.** Four of the five are advisory-only — no balance sheet, no trading floor. The fee pool splits across a class of tens, not hundreds. That is the $250k.
- **Goldman is the exception that proves it.** Same prestige and headhunter coverage, bulge-bracket class sizes, and comp nearer the top of A than the top of S.
- **You are buying the on-cycle list.** Megafund headhunters work these classes first. That is the entire economic case for the hours.

Failure mode: paying S-tier hours for an S-tier logo, then not running the process it was bought for.

A · The Bulge Brackets and the Near-Elite ★

$175K – $230K · 75–95 HRS · PJT, PWP, HOULIHAN LOKEY, JEFFERIES, MS, JPM, BOFA

- **The label does the least work here.** An RX seat at Houlihan Lokey and a coverage seat at BofA share a tier and nothing else — not hours, not modeling, not exits.
- **Group decides more than the bank.** Sponsors, LevFin, RX and strong M&A reach the buy side from any firm in this tier. Several coverage groups at the same firms do not.
- **MS / JPM / BofA is the honest street median:** ~$180k–$200k all-in, a class of hundreds, full on-cycle coverage. The base case the path is built around.

B · The Balance-Sheet Banks

$165K – $200K · 70–90 HRS · CITI, BARCLAYS, UBS, WELLS FARGO, RBC, TD, BNPP, DB, MIZUHO

- **Base matches; bonus does not.** Same base as the tier above, a year-end number $20k–$40k lower. Lending-led franchises fund smaller advisory pools.
- **Headhunter coverage is real but thinner.** On-cycle is reachable through a strong group with a live sponsor deal sheet — not through the logo.
- **The strongest group beats the tier.** Barclays or Citi sponsors outperforms the tier average, and it shows in exits.

C · Global Brands, Smaller US Platforms

$150K – $190K · 65–85 HRS · HSBC, NOMURA, SMBC, ROTHSCHILD, NATIXIS, CRÉDIT AGRICOLE

- **A US-desk judgment, not a global one.** Several are top-five at home and sub-scale in New York. For a Europe or Asia career, this tier is mis-labeled.
- **Best hours-per-dollar on the page:** roughly 80% of the B-tier number for meaningfully fewer hours. A real trade, not a consolation.
- **Exits run off-cycle:** middle-market, growth equity and credit, on real deal experience. Better process, shorter fund list.

D · Middle Market and Regional

$140K – $180K · 60–85 HRS · RAYMOND JAMES, STIFEL, WILLIAM BLAIR, BMO, CANACCORD, SEB, OPPENHEIMER

- **Worth most to the person without a better offer.** A signed seat here reaches the buy side. An unsigned S-tier application does not.
- **Location discounts the number.** Chicago, Tampa or St. Louis pays 10–20% under New York against a fraction of the rent — closer than the headline.
- **Deal exposure per analyst is often higher** — smaller teams, live processes, your own model. Exactly what off-cycle funds screen for.

The tier decides the pool. The group decides the number.

Take the 60-second quiz and get a personalized path from your current profile to the next seat on it.

TAKE THE QUIZ → wallstalpha.com/apply

Compensation figures are broad market ranges for US-based first-year analysts as of July 2026, drawn from published industry compensation reporting and prior-cycle patterns. They are not firm-specific offers, are not sourced from any firm, and vary materially by group, office, bonus bucket and year. Hours are self-reported community estimates and vary more by desk than by firm. Educational only; not affiliated with or endorsed by any firm named.